

A scene from the English National Opera's award-winning production of Glass's *Akhnaten*, directed by Phelim McDermott at the London Coliseum.

Inspiration and change

Returning to New York in 1967, Glass was inspired by the music of Steve Reich, which was taking a similar Minimalist route, with works for small ensembles using static harmonies and repetitive rhythmic patterns.

Although Glass was performing his own music regularly in New York, it did not provide him with a living. Having married in 1965, he was now starting a family, so to make ends meet he also worked as a mover, a plumber, and a cab driver.

By the mid-1970s, however, he had sufficiently established himself as a composer to concentrate on his music full-time. He embarked on a period of change in his musical style. With the series *Another Look at Harmony* (1975), he developed a more sophisticated brand of Minimalism, which he preferred to call “music with repetitive structures.” He also began to write more large-scale works. The first of these was the opera *Einstein on the Beach* (on the life of Albert Einstein), one of the trilogy of “portrait” operas along with *Satyagraha* (about Nelson Mandela) and *Akhnaten* (on the Egyptian pharaoh of that name).

Glass produced a huge volume of work in the 1980s, including operas and film scores. His first marriage had ended in divorce and was followed by a brief, unsuccessful second marriage, and a tragic third, which ended in 1991 when his wife, the artist Candy Jernigan, died of cancer. During this turbulent period in his personal life, Glass began to take an interest in composing more